

Speaker1: [00:00:00] I made a mistake; I sent the document. It's okay, you have it now. But I needed to open it with something other than Word, so it took me a while to figure that out. Here I am.

Speaker2: [00:00:09] That's great, everything is fine. At least you're back. Okay. Once again, thank you. Do you have any questions before we start?

Speaker1: [00:00:19] Uh... Well, no, no, it's fine. No.

Speaker2: [00:00:22] Very well.

Speaker1: [00:00:23] Since... Well, [ex-partner] is my ex-husband, so I know a bit about the principle of questionnaires and all, like he had for his thesis, I imagine. Is this for a thesis then?

Speaker2: [00:00:35] Not exactly. It's not a questionnaire, it's not questions, it's really your speech and your feelings that interest us. You can talk for as long as you want, take your time. And it's not for a thesis; it's for an international study focused on couple quality, aiming not only to create a scale but also to better understand the construct. I'm handling the [country] part, collecting data for [country], but there's also a part in the [country], the [country], the [country], etc.

Speaker1: [00:01:11] Okay, that works, okay.

Speaker2: [00:01:14] So to start, how would you like us to refer to your partner? Boyfriend, spouse, lover, partner?

Speaker1: [00:01:21] [partner].

Speaker2: [00:01:22] [partner] then, so by his name, yeah. And if I have to use another word than his first name, what... Partner, is that okay with you?

Speaker1: [00:01:28] Yes, my spouse.

Speaker2: [00:01:31] How long have you been with your spouse? With [partner].

Speaker1: [00:01:34] It's very recent, it's very recent. Now, it's been a year.

Speaker2: [00:01:38] Okay, very well.

Speaker1: [00:01:39] We're not young, but we're a young couple. (laughs) But we've known each other for a long time.

Speaker2: [00:01:44] You knew each other before.

Speaker1: [00:01:45] We were old neighbors, so we've known each other for more than [16-20] years. But yeah, it's been [1-5] year. We were both alone and ended up in each other's arms.

Speaker2: [00:01:55] I see. Well, to start, I'd like you to tell me about your current love story, the relationship you're experiencing with [partner], simply put.

Speaker1: [00:02:06] Uh. So for now, we don't live together yet, it's planned for the end of [month]. Uh, it's been a bit complicated for me these past [20-25] years. Uh. So a quick, surprising divorce. And then some complicated stories since and all... Yeah. And [partner] is someone very calm actually. Uh, I'm quite a fast-paced person and I needed someone calm. And I think last year, [1-5] and a half years ago, I ended a [6-10]-year relationship. And then... With psychological support, I understood things about the repetition of patterns. So I decided that... I decided I was very well on my own and... And last year, in [Month], I started demolishing the inside of my house to, to build already. Maybe symbolically. So I tore everything down. I knocked down a wall, expanded my living space. My children left the house. The second one left a while ago, but he came and went, and it's been [1-5] years since he's been in a relationship, so... But anyway, I think you'll see them, my children, because [ex-partner] must have given all the addresses.

Speaker2: [00:03:39] It's possible that I or a colleague of mine working on this might see them.

Speaker1: [00:03:43] Yeah, so [son] left [1-5] years ago, settled down for good, hopefully, with his girlfriend. So I found myself alone suddenly and happy. It was time since he was already [25-30]; I was glad he left the house finally. And then I started reclaiming the house for myself. Really. So I tore everything down last year, redid everything from floor to ceiling, changed the furniture, many things. And the work was just about to finish or was finishing. The kitchen was about to be installed. I had a problem with radiator leaks on my new parquet, and in the neighborhood, every time there was a technical problem, we called [partner]. Whatever the problem, he was always available to lend a hand. So I went to see [partner] who was moving because he was separated and had put the house up for sale, so he was working on his house just behind mine. So I went to see him, telling him I had a leak problem, and he said, "I'll come by during the week." And one evening he came by, and we talked as we knew each other well because he took care of the children more at his place, and at mine, it was more me. [ex-partner] was quite busy when they were little. And after we separated [16-20] years ago. So he was camping next door because there was no furniture left, but he was finishing painting and all. I was there, camping because I hadn't had a kitchen for two months. So I said, "Let's order a pizza and eat a pizza?" And yeah. It was nice. We spent the evening talking, and what was supposed to be just a repair job ended at 11:30 PM. And at 11:30 PM, he went home, and we continued exchanging messages. A few days later, I went for a walk near his place. He now lives 25 kilometers away. I went for a walk near his place along the [place]. I'm from [town], so I went for a walk near his place with the dog under the pretext of walking the dog. Animals are always a good excuse. And then he said, "Okay, but you kept me for dinner at your place the other day, so I'll keep you for dinner at mine." So we went, had dinner together, spent the evening together, and yeah. Then the evening ended, we felt good, and it started like that. We kissed, I went home, and we met again during the week. It was a bit complicated at first because the divorce was dragging, even though since last [Month], the divorce had been filed, and they were separated, but it was still not finalized. So we hope it will be in [Month]. But at

first, [redacted]. At over [46-50] years old, it was a bit. It was a bit annoying, but it made us laugh. We felt like teenagers again. [Redacted].

Speaker2: [00:08:08] So if I understand correctly, the complicated divorce was on his side. It was on his side where it could be complicated.

Speaker1: [00:08:47] Yes.

Speaker2: [00:08:47] You also mentioned feeling like teenagers, sneaking through the hedge, etc. Was that something significant in the beginning of the relationship?

Speaker1: [00:08:57] Yeah, it was... Yeah, there was something sparkling about it, a side... At the same time, it was frustrating because we wanted to live things openly. We felt good from the start, and we sensed things were going well. We knew each other for a long time, and we had affinities as neighbors. But yeah, once he was available, and so was I, even though I thought, "I'm fine on my own now; I've got my house, I've been alone, I'll be fine." Well, things happened, and we decided, [partner] will leave his rented house by the end of [month], and we'll move in together. But we'll see what happens. Sometimes he gets a bit anxious, but I think it's normal. He hasn't gone through what I have, struggling with relationships since my divorce. I had [1-5] relationships, one for [1-5] years and one for [6-10] years, and they were complicated. So I decided to first understand the pattern I was repeating. I realized I was too empathetic and attracted people who needed a crutch. So I felt drained each time and couldn't find myself. So yeah.

Speaker2: [00:10:39] You mentioned "since your divorce," is that your first divorce?

Speaker1: [00:10:43] Yeah, I've only had one divorce, one marriage, one divorce. With [ex-partner].

Speaker2: [00:10:49] With [ex-partner]. Very well. So if I understand correctly, you knew [partner] while raising your children, and he was raising his at the same time. It's not just a neighbor; it's someone you interacted with because you were both raising...

Speaker1: [00:11:14] Yes, because when the kids were in primary school, I wasn't in this house yet, so we weren't neighbors. We lived in the same small town near [town], but we were both active in the school's parent association. He was a very involved dad, organizing school events, and I was a very involved mom. His wife, his ex-wife, not at all, and [ex-partner] not much either due to lack of time. So we got to know each other well that way; we had a similar approach with our kids.

Speaker2: [00:11:48] The development of the relationship - I know it's been a short time, just a [1-5] years - but you've described a lot about the beginning. How has it developed over these [5-10] years of the relationship?

Speaker1: [00:12:04] We're learning to build the relationship because it's not always easy. I think he had a wife who was the complete opposite of me; he complained she didn't talk, while I

talk too much. So he had a wife who wasn't very communicative, and it was hard for him to know what she was thinking or feeling. She didn't talk to neighbors; we never talked to her either. She was very distant. So he's learning. Sometimes I go a bit too fast for him. I think I go a bit too fast for him. And jokingly, he says he has trouble keeping up with me. I'm always a bit too active. He needs to take things one at a time. He needed to build trust in this relationship. I think at first, [partner] was a bit scared because I'm a teacher, and he's a maintenance technician. He thought [participant] wasn't for him. But now I realize he fits me on many levels. We have common aspirations, we want to build together. We have a shared vision that I didn't have with the people I was with since my divorce [15-20] years ago. The two people I met had personal aspirations, not couple aspirations. What I like about [partner] is that we have a joint vision. Quickly, he told his children in [Month] because he didn't want to hide it from them. Logically, my kids knew from the start, but he needed to tell his to feel good, and it relieved him. The eldest daughter said it was a bit soon for her mother, it would be complicated, and they shouldn't tell the mother. So the kids chose not to tell her, but he was ready to say it to her. So from [Month], once they knew, they were less anxious about it - because I sensed quite a bit of anxiety at times - and yeah, it's... What else? He quickly introduced me to his family. Brother, sister... Friends. It happened quickly, by [month]. [1-5] months after we were together.

Speaker2: [00:14:51] Organically.

Speaker1: [00:14:53] Yeah, absolutely.

Speaker2: [00:14:56] You mentioned therapy, understanding the patterns you were reproducing, deconstructing them to understand better, which helped you. Do you think [partner] might not have done that, or if he did, how has it influenced your relationship? You mentioned attachment issues, and I'm curious how that played out for both of you in building this relationship.

Speaker1: [00:15:33] I think [partner] was scared at some point because things were moving fast. And actually, as I had decided not to get into another relationship and felt good on my own, with friends and all, I found balance. I told myself I was fine alone. And then [partner] came along, and I quickly felt comfortable. I don't hide my feelings, so I quickly expressed what I felt. He was on the same page. But sometimes he might have a tendency - but I'm working on this with my therapist - a tendency towards depression, a depressive state. He has cyclical phases where the smallest thing can overwhelm him with the amount of things to do because we are dealing with two houses, it's complicated. There have been significant events in our lives since we've been together. He lost a sister; I lost an uncle of my age, who grew up with me, was raised with me. We've experienced strong events that have made us question things. For him, it has been complicated. He had already lost two brothers before and his father quite young, so it has reactivated things for him. I feel like family takes up a lot of space for him. My family is far away, mainly in [region], but his entire family is around [town], almost all of them. He was one of [6-10] siblings initially; now there are only [6-10] left. His mother is still there. Whenever there's a problem in the family, it's usually [partner], even though he's the eighth child, not the eldest, who steps in and absorbs all the family issues. That sometimes affects the couple because he's hypersensitive and doesn't always have a lot of self-confidence. Everyone tells him everything,

and things can get complicated. I try to help, but sometimes I feel like I can't do anything. So in my last session with my therapist last Thursday, I said, "I'm a bit lost because he himself is lost, and it's sometimes complicated in the relationship." I feel like he puts on the brakes a lot. One time he says, "We'll buy a tiny house and live by the [Location], and run a guest house for people biking along the [Location]." Another time, he says, "We'll buy a house together," or, "We'll empty my big garage and turn it into a workshop where we can do things together." Then last week, he said, "I think I need a place where I can recharge alone with a workshop to tinker." The thing is, [partner] is [51-55], and he worked with asbestos for a while, so he'll retire in two years while I don't even know what retirement is. So there's a bit of a disconnect, but I sense he's in a phase where his life is completely disrupted. I've told him I'm there for him, to support him, but I fear falling back into patterns of over-empathy. Sometimes I question it, but I know I care deeply for him, so I tell myself I'll do what's necessary to make it work and support him because we're not just here for the good times. I know who he is; he's a good person with values. We have shared values, and I believe in him. I believe in us.

Speaker2: [00:20:13] You've spoken at length about this relationship, its development, and how it was created. I'd like to know if you had to compare the quality of your relationship with [partner] to that of your friends, what would you say?

Speaker1: [00:20:28] It's funny you ask that because we recently went on a weekend with friends. Quite often. Well, we're very tactile. All our friends say, "That's because you're a young couple, up to [1-5] years, and then it's over." But I don't think I've ever felt this way, even in previous relationships. This need to be together, this... I think there was something off in the relationships with the two people between [ex-partner] and [partner]. There was something wrong, something where I didn't feel like a decision-maker. But here, it's really the idea of a shared vision that I like because I feel we're on the same wavelength. I don't think I'm wrong here, even if "a scalded cat fears cold water." But we've been together for [1-5] year, talking about living together, and I feel confident in this relationship, which I never felt with my previous relationships of [1-5] and [6-10] years. Those were not without turmoil. It wasn't simple. So yeah, I don't know if I've answered, if I haven't strayed too far...

Speaker2: [00:21:57] Again, what interests me is what you say. There's no right or wrong answer. You've mostly compared it to your previous relationships. If you want, you can expand on that: if you had to compare the quality of your current relationship with [partner] to your previous ones, do you have anything to add?

Speaker1: [00:22:20] Yes, I think - when I met [ex-partner], I was [15-20], and we separated when I was [35-40]. I lived [20-25] years with [ex-partner]. He was really the great love for me, the pillar of the house, and when we separated, everything fell apart. It was very complicated, and I think I've always sought that trust, that stability. A person I can rely on, which I have finally found. But I had [15-20] very complicated years. So being with [partner], feeling confident, and sensing because we talk a lot, feeling that... Well, I make him talk a lot. I talk all the time, so feeling that the relationship is serene, well, it's serene. Yes and no. Because when he's in a phase of apathy, questioning, or anxious thoughts, when he's in that phase, it can be complicated. I try to... I try to put things in perspective, take a step back. I listen to podcasts, I

hold back. But yeah, I feel compared to the relationship... Well, the relationship with [ex-partner], I was [15-20] until I was [35-40]; I had my children. For me, it was for life, there was no doubt about it. So I took a big hit when we separated, and I didn't expect it. So after that, I had to redevelop trust, work on fear of abandonment. I worked a lot on that and talked a lot with [partner]. Sometimes he reminds me regularly that he's not like the others, that he's someone reliable, dependable, etc. And I know that because I knew him before, and that reassures me.

Speaker2: [00:24:24] You mentioned in this comparison with your current relationship and your past ones, the feeling that you are going in the same direction, the feeling of trust you've struggled to regain. Are there other differences in your current relationship in terms of what you feel and the quality of this relationship compared to previous ones?

Speaker1: [00:24:50] Yes. There's really a fusion, a couple dynamic where, I don't know, many things work well. And curiously, when you're with someone, you might say, "Oh, I don't like this or that." But I don't feel that way with [partner]. Even if there might be flaws in a person, I accept everything. Actually, I love everything, and I would say any flaws he might have are outweighed by his qualities. It's great. (laughs) Whereas before, I would think, "Oh no, I can't stand that." As if I was picky, even though I don't think I am. I feel I endured a lot in previous relationships. So now I don't have those questions. I don't want to question the relationship. I love him, period. I love him as he is; I accept him as he is. I don't want to change anything.

Speaker2: [00:26:01] If I understand correctly, you mentioned that you endured things in previous relationships and that might be linked to the difficult breakup. You lost trust in others, and maybe with [partner], you're finding that again, not feeling like you're enduring, feeling like equals.

Speaker1: [00:26:20] Yes. Yes. Exactly. I feel like equals. I feel myself, there's no pretending. Everything is clear, transparent. And when things aren't going well, we talk.

Speaker2: [00:26:38] You talk.

Speaker1: [00:26:39] We talk. Yeah, we talk. Even when he doesn't talk, I go to him and say, "If you want to talk." And he ends up talking, saying, "You're right, we need to talk; it helps." He wasn't used to talking. In his family, what shocks him is all the unspoken things. For example, he lost a sister to a stroke, who was my age, [1-5] months ago. He found her with another sister, and it wasn't easy because she lived alone. At the funeral, there were tensions with the ex-husband, the father of her children, who hadn't shown up for [20-25] years. He reappeared and caused trouble, attacking everyone. It was complicated. *[Next statements has been redacted.]*

Speaker2: [00:30:16] Coming back to our earlier discussion about your friends, are there things you would say about what you experience with [partner] compared to what your friends experience with their partners?

Speaker1: [00:30:33] I have many friends - being alone for many years, I have many single friends. Otherwise, I find that in many couples, there's a lack of communication, kindness, attention. I see couples making digs at each other, and I think it's horrible. We've been on trips

with friends, and one couple is okay, but there's a lack of tender gestures, attention. Yeah. They're not young couples necessarily, but there's a lack of attention. Given my experiences, I think it's important to... I believe it's important to say and show things, to have attentions.

Speaker2: [00:31:35] Do you think it's because they're not "young couples" anymore, as you said, that there are these unspoken things or lack of attention?

Speaker1: [00:31:41] I don't know... Or maybe it was a mismatch from the start. It's curious to think, for example, about flaws you accept or not. For example, [partner] snores, and before, I would think, "Oh no, he snores, it's unbearable." Now, I think, "Well, he snores, so what? I'll get used to it; it's not a big deal." Or body odors. There might be body odors that bother you in someone else. When [partner] comes back from sports and smells of sweat, it doesn't bother me. Whereas before, it wouldn't have been that way. There are signs that show there's a kind of... And sometimes I think it's a bit silly to say this because it's only been a year, we're a new couple, and I feel I'm experiencing emotions. Yeah, emotions. But I feel there's a strong chemistry. When you really feel that, you shouldn't question it about the... [relationship] Which I don't feel with other couples.

Speaker1: [00:33:10] That you don't feel with other couples.

Speaker2: [00:33:10] That I don't feel with other couples. Other couples must find us annoying because we're always talking, laughing, sharing looks about things we've heard. We have a connection, a complicity. Yeah, it's obvious we're happy together. We went to dinner with two other couples at a restaurant [1-5] weeks ago, and they seated us apart. [partner] and I looked at each other, and [partner] moved the guests around, saying, "I can't be far from [participant]." While still enjoying the company of others, we love our friends.

Speaker2: [00:34:03] I'm listening to you.

Speaker1: [00:34:05] We don't live in a bubble. What's great too is the relationship with our children because our children went to the same school. [partner]'s youngest is younger, only [16-20], almost [16-20]. But his [1-5] older daughters are the same age as my daughter, his eldest, and my son, his second. They know each other since they were little because we were neighbors, and they shared classes. We had a reunion with all of them recently, and it was great. Something I never could do with the people I met before because they didn't want to introduce me to their kids. Someone told me, "I can't introduce you to my kids because one doesn't want to see you, and the other one doesn't want you to meet the grandchildren because they'll tell their grandmother, my ex-wife." So I felt completely illegitimate. I think the transparency, the fact that [partner] quickly wanted to tell his kids and introduce me to his family was really important.

Speaker2: [00:35:31] You've mentioned several things, transparency, communication, complicity, trust. Can you describe what a high-quality relationship is for you?

Speaker1: [00:35:45] Oh, yeah, it's transparency... While giving the other freedom. One plus one equals three. There's the couple, but also the individual. That's important. We talked about

it, and it's important that each remains themselves. I can fully be myself with [partner], and he can fully be himself with me, and we find balance in the couple because we respect each other. No criticism, no desire to change the other. Accepting the other as they are and just enjoying the everyday. For example, he's not here today; he went to his place tonight; he had things to do. Tomorrow night he'll be here, and when you see him, he'll likely be at my place, and I'll be out with friends. We have our individual spaces, but we're so happy to be together. For me, a quality relationship is having a shared vision. It's funny, the painting behind me, do you see it?

Speaker2: [00:37:08] Yes.

Speaker1: [00:37:09] It's a coincidence that it's right behind, but I saw it earlier and thought, "This painting, when I bought it, maybe [11-15] years ago, it represented a couple to me." It depicts a couple experiencing things together, there's an atmosphere of unity as they toast together in a café, despite the rainy weather outside. They're projecting towards a light, somewhat reminiscent of [Name's] idea that love isn't about looking at each other but looking together in the same direction. It's this aspect of a shared vision. I love this painting. Anyway, I had a crush on it when I bought it.

Speaker2: [00:37:55] You used a lot of different adjectives to describe a high-quality relationship. You said freedom, transparency, and you talked about trust.

Speaker1: [00:38:09] Yes.

Speaker2: [00:38:12] If you had to choose one adjective in particular to describe a high-quality relationship, what would you choose? A high-quality relationship is a relationship...

Speaker1: [00:38:26] Of trust. Trust.

Speaker2: [00:38:29] How can you know that you're in a relationship of trust?

Speaker1: [00:38:34] Well, it's not easy, especially for me because I really experienced the wounds of betrayal, rejection, abandonment, humiliation, and injustice when I separated [15-20] years ago. I felt it all. And it was really hard to get over it. It's because I feel trust with [partner], because I knew him before, I know who he is in life. And it's because I feel trust that I think I accepted getting into a relationship in the first place. I told myself he's really a good person, otherwise, I think I wouldn't have even - well, I wasn't looking to meet someone new. I thought, "Well, no, you need to find your own balance, you have your friends, you go out, you do things, you have work," but... I think I was really afraid to enter a new relationship and fall again. I didn't want to relive betrayal...

Speaker2: [00:39:32] What made you feel trust in this case?

Speaker1: [00:39:36] Because I knew him, because... I don't know, it's just him. Because of what he represents, who he is. He has a particular sensitivity. He's someone empathetic, like me, I think. He's reliable, I feel it. That's how everyone knows him. And...

Speaker2: [00:40:01] You said like me. Does that mean potentially a relationship of trust is also one where you recognize yourself in the other, or at least you feel you understand them?

Speaker1: [00:40:10] Yeah, there are ways we really resemble each other and we both find it amazing how often we think the same thing at the same time. It might be coincidence, but even when it has nothing to do with our current situation. We have this kind of... I don't know, maybe it's connivance. It's just feeling things or wanting the same things. Yeah, we have common desires, we see things the same way. We're both into ecology, and I feel we vibe in the same way. And that's something really about feeling; it's stronger. Of course, everyone has a shadow side, but I see more clearly since being with him, in my life, in my future, I feel more confident.

Speaker2: [00:41:11] When did you realize that your relationship with [partner] was a relationship of trust?

Speaker1: [00:41:16] When did I realize? Well, when we were together, so late [month] last year and in [month], about a month later, I was going to visit my parents. I was stressed about the drive alone. I planned to go by car because I have a [pet]. And I sensed he wasn't ready to come with me, that it was too soon. Facing my family, it was too much, too fast, too intense. So he told me. And when he said, "[Participant], there's no problem, I keep my word, I said I would go with you, we go together, I'll accompany you all the way to [location]." After that, it's just an hour more. So I said okay. He bought his train ticket, and we went down in two days. We talked a lot during those two days because I thought it was over. I was so scared that I put up a shield, my protection, and I thought "I made a mistake." But he told me, "No, no, it's not over, it's just that it needs to go slower, we need to take our time because this is overwhelming for me, it's very strong. I've never experienced this." He had been with his ex-wife for [30-35] years, she was practically the only one he had known. So he wasn't ready. He wasn't ready for so much positivity, happiness all at once, it overwhelmed him. He felt submerged. He felt submerged. So he put on the brakes, saying "We need to see each other less, I need to get my bearings, find myself a bit alone, re-center myself." So I cried for three days (laughs) and thought "I'll go down alone." Then I called him, explained everything, and he said, "No, I never intended for it to be over. But since you weren't responding, I thought it was." But he said, "I told you I'd go with you, I'm going with you." And that's when I realized I could trust him. If he commits, he really commits. It's the first time I felt I could trust him. Since I had known him for a long time, I knew he was someone people could rely on, I knew others who knew him and said, "Yeah, he's a good guy." We have mutual friends we've known for a long time. So yeah, that's when I realized he was reliable. Even if he took the train back, I thought, no, actually, when he commits, he follows through. He said he'd do it, and he did. And then gradually, things built up. As I talk about with my therapist, you shouldn't want to go too fast and indeed, build things, build the couple.

Speaker2: [00:44:25] Conversely, when was this relationship the least trustworthy?

Speaker1: [00:44:31] When?

Speaker2: [00:44:32] When was it the least trustworthy?

Speaker1: [00:44:35] Hmm... I'd say when I lost confidence in myself. When I started to doubt. When he's not well, when he has these depressive states that can last from [1-5] days to a week. It's happened four or five times since we've been together, especially after his sister's death. Seeing him completely - not prostrate, but absent. Not talking, withdrawing a bit. I questioned myself and thought, "What did I do? What am I doing? Why is he in doubt?" And so, yeah, that's when I could indeed doubt.

Speaker2: [00:45:39] You told me earlier what a high-quality relationship is for you. I'd like to know what a low-quality relationship is for you.

Speaker1: [00:45:50] An interest-based relationship. A relationship not based on love, but a relationship... An unbalanced relationship. A relationship where one or the other can't find fulfillment because of the other's attitude. Someone who is particularly selfish, who only thinks, for example, about their career or money. For me, that would be a low-quality relationship, or a man - or a woman - who is unfaithful, living their life on the side. A relationship not based on trust, in other words.

Speaker2: [00:46:43] You used two other words. You said a relationship that is interest-based or unbalanced. Similarly, how can you know you're in an unbalanced or interest-based relationship?

Speaker1: [00:46:59] Unbalanced is when you're not happy with the person you're with. You think, "He's gone off again" or "She's not home again, out partying with friends while I'm stuck with the kids and chores." Someone who works equally but too much self-sacrifice on one side, I'd say. That's something I've experienced.

Speaker2: [00:47:31] Something you experienced in your previous relationships.

Speaker1: [00:47:33] Or in my marriage, at the end.

Speaker2: [00:47:38] In that case, when was your current relationship the most unbalanced?

Speaker1: [00:47:47] Well, not yet. I haven't gone through that phase yet. Maybe slightly when... No, not even. Sometimes when we plan to spend a week together, and then he says, "I need some quiet time, I'll come over tomorrow instead," and I think, well, he's deciding, and I don't feel like a decision-maker. Or I tell him, "Come over when you want," and I make myself available, and he makes himself available when he can or wants. But that's not really [partner], it's not... When he does that, it's because he really needs to recharge. So I understand that and accept it more easily.

Speaker2: [00:48:36] And when has it been the most interest-based, if it has been?

Speaker1: [00:48:41] No, I don't think so. I don't think it has happened. But we're a young couple.

Speaker2: [00:48:51] I'd like you to talk to me about the things that are most important to you in a romantic relationship.

Speaker1: [00:49:01] From my experience, what destroyed my relationships? The last long relationship I had for [10-15] years. He was [10-15] years older than me, retired, so he didn't have the same rhythm. We shared common interests, like theater, but he was into directing and writing, and I felt used for his sketches or plays. He only thought about that. It turned me off theater, and I stopped for [1-5] years. That's what ended our relationship. He didn't take it well, but I needed to... I went back to theater after we separated. But the imbalance also came from different rhythms and no shared vision. Someone wanting to live day by day for their own desires. That was my previous relationship. He couldn't project, didn't want to. With anyone, in anything. He couldn't project.

Speaker2: [00:50:30] So you're saying what's important to you in a relationship is the projection.

Speaker1: [00:50:35] It's having short, medium, and long-term projects, a shared vision. It's mostly that it's shared, having the same desires. If we're too distant, not aspiring to the same things, it can't work. That's what killed my marriage, I think. I had a very career-driven husband, always, and I felt I had to step back to take care of the kids. It was complicated.

Speaker2: [00:51:14] We've talked about relationships, quality relationships, etc. What you can put behind them, what you can put behind them. I'd like you to talk to me about what love is for you, based on your experience.

Speaker1: [00:51:24] Yeah. I received love as a child. I feel I had a loving family, solid foundations of family love. Even with some small hiccups, we realize later. But overall, I felt love from my family, from grandparents to parents. I felt that. When I talk about shared values, for example, with [partner], I think he had that too. My previous relationship was with someone who didn't receive love from his mother, who abandoned him, and I don't know if a person can feel love simply if there were such lacks in childhood. My previous relationship's big issue was fear of abandonment. He was convinced from the start, because he was older, that I would leave him, that it was impossible for me not to leave one day. But mostly, his big issue was age. Before we entered a romantic relationship, he was introduced by someone else and became my best friend. We shared a lot. After [1-5] year or two, he became my partner. We never really lived together. He left me regularly. In [10-15] years, he left about [10-15] times. He'd disappear, no news, and then come back. It was unbearable. That destroys a lot. For me, feeling love for someone also depends on what you received yourself. It's a bit about trusting the other, so if there's no basic trust, no childhood security, I don't know if you can really trust the other. I thought I couldn't anymore, but I'm learning again. I'm learning to let go and tell myself, "It's okay, everything's fine."

Speaker2: [00:54:01] You say loving is about letting go.

Speaker1: [00:54:04] A bit. Not letting go, but... yeah. How to say. Letting go.

Speaker2: [00:54:16] Trusting the other. Is that what you mean?

Speaker1: [00:54:17] Trusting the other without losing yourself. Keeping your values, your personality. Always that one plus one equals three, keeping your values, your personality while being... Yeah. Trusting. At some point, you need to stop questioning. Loving is also seeing in the other what you want to find.

Speaker2: [00:54:53] How important is love in a relationship for you?

Speaker1: [00:54:57] It's the foundation. In a couple, it's the foundation. Yeah, it's the foundation. But it might be skewed because we're a young couple. For example, my parents have 60 years of marriage. I asked if they were interested in participating in this interview because it could be interesting for you to have someone [80-85] years old. They have experience with highs and lows, etc. But they've been married for [56-60] years, and that's rare today. My parents are very different but very complementary. My mom always says, "Happiness is built daily." Loving is also about intelligence. My mom, [76-80] years old, says "Loving is intelligence." They met quickly, had to marry, etc. She says, "Happiness is built daily and maintained intelligently." They're very different, always arguing, but they built themselves like that. They can't separate from each other. My mom had four cancers, and my dad was desperate but very present for her. They really need each other. But sometimes we look at them and think, "Oh my God!"

Speaker2: [00:56:40] We know there can be many forms and ways of loving. I'd like you to tell me how you know your partner loves you.

Speaker1: [00:56:51] Through attentions, looks, gestures. It's something beyond words. It's really about the overall feeling. The desire to please the other before pleasing oneself. Always asking the other's opinion, "Do you agree with this?" Ensuring the other is on the same page.

Speaker2: [00:57:37] Considering the other.

Speaker1: [00:57:38] Yes, that's it. Yes, of course, that's it.

Speaker2: [00:57:42] It's a way to know your partner loves you, because they consider you.

Speaker1: [00:57:46] Yes. In romantic and human relationships.

Speaker2: [00:57:53] I'd like you to tell me about one of the last positive interactions you had with your partner, with your spouse.

Speaker1: [00:58:01] Hmm... Well... There are always many. (laughs) Trying to find one. We send each other lots of little messages during the day, insignificant things. For example, yesterday, we were planning a vacation. I said, "I'd like to go hiking in [location] with a donkey this summer." He said, "Okay, let's do it." He sent me an email, saying, "Look, I found something while at work, it looks great." So that's a plan for this summer, for late [month], hiking for four days together. I mention something, and he immediately responds positively, "Great idea." That's great, but we have interactions like this all the time. Last night, he said, "Let's clear out your garden, sort out your old pots, and make a nice spot." I said, "You're making it for us

both." He agreed, saying he needs to think like that. Often, he says "your garden," "I'm doing your garden." But he's arriving now, and he weeded the vegetable patch, saying, "Look, I brought some tomato plants." These are things that show he wants to do things with me. We have constant interactions, in daily exchanges, words, gestures, attentions. It seems idyllic; hope it lasts. (laughs) But yeah.

Speaker2: [00:59:55] Conversely, tell me about one of the last negative interactions you had with your spouse.

Speaker1: [01:00:02] Well... Trying to recall. Ah yes. For my parents' wedding anniversary, we took a small cruise on the [Location] with my whole family. We left from [City] and sailed for five days, and [partner] was invited. My parents wanted to gather the family for their anniversary. So we were eleven. We're not a big family on my side, so it was very nice. After the cruise, my sister, who I don't get along with very well, but it's improving after [46-50] years, stayed with my parents for [1-5] days. We went to a bar near an old lockkeeper's house, very nice, just the three of us, my sister, [partner], and me. It was really nice. Then we went home, had another drink on the terrace, talking about many things. At one point, I said, "It's time to make dinner. What should we do?" [partner] said, "Let's have another drink." I said, "Enough, enough." He said, and it really shocked me, "I'll join you after, but I'll have another drink with your sister." I looked at him and said, "No, no." I felt a wave of jealousy, reminding me of my teenage years when my sister stole my boyfriends. It put me in a bad place. I felt bad all evening. When we went to bed, [partner] asked, "What's wrong?" I explained, "I didn't like how you behaved with my sister." He apologized, saying he didn't realize. I said, "Put yourself in my shoes. If we were with your brother and I said, [partner], go make dinner while I have a drink with your brother, how would you feel?" He agreed it was wrong. But we talked about it, and it passed. But I really didn't like it. Maybe because it triggered negative memories. It's probably irrational with [partner], but still there.

Speaker2: [01:03:05] You mentioned earlier considering the other.

Speaker1: [01:03:09] Yes, I didn't feel it at all then. Yeah.

Speaker2: [01:03:15] You've already talked a bit about it, but I'd like you to discuss the challenges in your relationship.

Speaker1: [01:03:31] Hmm... The challenges. Have I already mentioned them?

Speaker2: [01:03:37] You mentioned things that could be considered challenges. But it's up to you to choose the words.

Speaker1: [01:03:47] I think a big challenge is making him feel at home in my place. That's not easy, I think. It's a house I bought behind his. At the end of my garden, you can see the wall of his old house. It's hard for him because of the past. The challenge is to make him feel good here. I've stopped many things since being with him, like the decorating downstairs. I said, "We'll decide together, we'll do it together." I was going to redo the bathrooms upstairs, but I said, "We'll see together how to do it, if we close one bathroom." I had the budget because I

took a loan for it. He said, "No, you're right because if I want to feel at home, I should do the bathroom myself." He likes DIY. So that's a challenge. For me, the challenge is making him feel good in my place. I aim to empty this 50-square-meter garage full of my past to make space for his things, to give him his own space. It's clearing half my closets to make room for him. Yeah, that's a challenge. That's one of the challenges.

Speaker2: [01:05:17] Very well. We know that sometimes in a relationship, not everything is rosy. I'd like you to talk about conflicts or disputes you might have with your partner.

Speaker1: [01:05:28] There aren't many conflicts, actually. We're not conflictual. I had a conflictual husband, so I always aimed for peace. I can't, I wouldn't go to conflict. I'll let go. But I work on conflict management in my job. I'm responsible for helping teachers in high school and middle school in my department with conflict management in the classroom. I'm the only one doing this. Handling conflicts between teachers and students, or between students. We always say, "At some point, you need to stop the ping-pong game, let go of the racket." I practice that in my personal life too. There comes a point where it's pointless to continue, you need to lay things out. Professionally, it's different from personal life. But I try to step back, analyze things instead of reacting in the heat of the moment when possible. Sometimes things hit hard, but I always try to analyze, which means I avoid conflict as much as possible.

Speaker2: [01:06:57] You wouldn't define the interaction you mentioned earlier with your sister and [partner] as a conflict or a dispute?

Speaker1: [01:07:04] No, because I clammed up. I put up my shield, I wasn't feeling well. I didn't say anything at the time. It was because he probed that I explained, "I didn't feel good because." I could explain. But I wouldn't go to conflict. Maybe with someone else, they wouldn't have looked for why I wasn't well.

Speaker2: [01:07:31] So for you, it's not a conflict because it requires both parties. It can't be a conflict from one side only.

Speaker1: [01:07:42] Well... Yes, it's an internal conflict. Inside, everything is in turmoil, and I blow things out of proportion. But not a conflict with others. I don't like going to conflict with others; I prefer explaining and reflecting. But it shows when I'm not well. He knows now, he understands and asks, "What's wrong? Talk to me." And vice versa. If he's not well, I know. And if we talk, it generally gets better. Whether it's about work or anything else, he talks to me. It's about listening and words.

Speaker2: [01:08:28] You'd say that what prevents conflicts, what avoids them, is listening and communication more broadly.

Speaker1: [01:08:35] Yes, of course. Yeah. Kindness in the couple too.

Speaker2: [01:08:42] Kindness, you say. What do you mean by kindness?

Speaker1: [01:08:48] It's a trendy word. But it's about not seeing everything negatively. Analyzing things in relation to oneself, realizing "I react this way towards him," but the fault isn't all on one side. When I explained, I said, "I felt this way because I don't trust my sister. It's ingrained from our childhood and adolescence. So when you do that with my sister..." I said, "But if you did that with anyone, it would make me uncomfortable in terms of self-confidence. So it's that kind of situation that bothers me." He said, "It's good you told me because I didn't mean anything by it." But it wasn't about conflict; it was about defusing it. If he had said, "Stop sulking, it's no big deal," and gotten defensive, it could have led to conflict. Or I might have shut down more. But in a couple, it's important to always be willing to talk to defuse situations.

Speaker2: [01:10:20] I'd like to know what could make you leave your current partner.

Speaker1: [01:10:30] I've asked myself that because... If I felt betrayed by him not doing anything to fight his depression, or if he isolated himself. If it lasted too long, it would be complicated. I talked about it with my therapist because it's important for me to be there for him. I want to help him, but I also want him to see someone to help him. I want to be there as a close person to someone in a depressive state. At some point, you can't do everything. My therapist said, "I need to watch out for you because you shouldn't carry [partner] at the expense of your happiness." It makes me unhappy to see him like that. If the episodes become more frequent, it could be something I struggle with long-term. I need joy and happiness. I think he will do what's necessary. He analyzes things.

Speaker2: [01:12:20] I'd like to know how you maintain your relationship. You've mentioned it a bit.

Speaker1: [01:12:32] Spontaneity. It's good to have shared projects, but there should also be spontaneous things. For example, if he comes home in the evening and doesn't want to be there, I say, "Let's go for a drink in town." Or something original. Once, for [Event], I made him a jar with little smarties shaped like hearts and little notes saying, "A weekend in [Location]" or "A weekend in [Location]." When he picks a note, we try to do it. It started with notes but now we do it spontaneously. "Let's go to a restaurant tonight" when we need a change. We try not to fall into routine.

Speaker2: [01:13:54] Into routine.

Speaker1: [01:13:55] Routine kills.

Speaker2: [01:13:59] Would you say this relationship is good for you?

Speaker1: [01:14:01] Yes, I think it's good for me; it's fulfilling. For now, it's fulfilling. There are moments - we often talk about it - when we're there, thinking, "Is this really happening?" It's so strong, what we feel. There's so much connection and complicity. We're still surprised by it after a year.

Speaker2: [01:14:40] I'll clarify a bit what I mean by good relationships - though I'm also interested in what you think. It's about daily functioning regulated by the relationship. The relationship helps us regulate ourselves daily, to feel good, and to achieve our goals as well.

Speaker1: [01:15:06] Yes, I think so. Yes, I think so because I'm more positive, more cheerful, I think. Even though I'm not naturally someone who lets themselves go. When I sink, if I have a problem, I need to bounce back quickly. I'm quite resilient in that way. But yes, on a daily basis, I wake up in the morning and think, "It's nice to have someone waiting for me somewhere," and at work, I think, "It's okay, I'll talk to [partner] about it tonight," whereas before, I was alone. Even in my relationships, I felt alone in many things.

Speaker2: [01:15:49] Do you have concrete examples of moments, situations, or interactions that have helped you regulate yourself or achieve your goals, whether personal or professional?

Speaker1: [01:16:06] Not yet. Nothing obvious. It doesn't come to mind easily for now. It doesn't come to mind.

Speaker2: [01:16:20] I'd also like to know if you think you are the same person as before your current relationship. In other words, has this relationship changed you?

Speaker1: [01:16:29] No, I don't think so. I don't think I've changed. Actually. I think there have been relationships in the past that changed me, where I felt a bit different because I felt like I had to be someone else or that I wasn't fully myself. In this relationship, no, I feel like myself.

Speaker2: [01:17:01] You feel like yourself.

Speaker1: [01:17:03] Yeah, I feel really... accepted as I am.

Speaker2: [01:17:08] You mentioned at the beginning of the interview this idea of deconstruction, that you were reproducing patterns. Maybe you don't feel this relationship has helped you achieve goals or regulate because you had already changed before the relationship. You had already done all this work, and now you're applying it. Once you discovered or understood certain things about yourself, you can now live your relationship more serenely.

Speaker1: [01:17:47] I started therapy about [1-5] years ago, I think. [1-5] and a half years. And I think that breaking down walls, opening my house, changing everything was already a mental cleanse and a desire to move forward. I was in a very positive dynamic when I met [partner]. I understood many things about not necessarily attracting the right people. Maybe I was too attentive to others. Yeah, I wasn't attracting the right people because maybe I wanted to save them from something. I don't know. There was a sensitivity in those people that touched me. Though I had different relationships. But yeah, I wasn't attracting the right people. Either I attracted people to rebuild myself as a woman after my divorce - that was the person I was with for three years, where I regained confidence as a woman. But the ten-year relationship was with someone very tortured, and I think he hurt me. I was constantly in doubt. He kept persuading me that we were meant for each other, that he couldn't leave, but he was lost and wanted to come back. It was complicated. So I go on about my stuff.

Speaker2: [01:19:49] Again, what interests me is your feelings, your experience.

Speaker1: [01:19:53] Yes, okay.

Speaker2: [01:19:55] Similarly, do you feel your partner has changed during your relationship? Has this relationship changed him?

Speaker1: [01:20:05] I feel he lacked confidence and doubted many things. I feel - and he also tells me - after all, I don't know what he will tell you. But I feel [partner] has really gained confidence over the past year and is beginning to see things, especially regarding his family. Even if I haven't pointed it out, I don't judge, but I feel he can analyze things. For example, when my family gets together, it's always for the best. He sees in his family, there are many reproaches, many things, a lot of "we should do this, but so-and-so said this, but she doesn't want to." It's very complicated, and it eats him up. He's starting to realize this. Before, he was always there whenever they called because nothing was happening in his love life. He said it had been more than fifteen years, and almost all the neighbors and mutual friends noticed things were bad with his ex-wife, and he wasn't happy. I think it was a way for him to escape, to leave his house. He talks about it easily now. And now, I think he wants to live, do things, travel like me, meet new people.

Speaker2: [01:21:50] So you think your relationship has changed him.

Speaker1: [01:21:54] Yes, I think so. It changed him, but it helped him. It's very pretentious, but I think it propels him to something else. It shakes him up, but I feel it's mostly positive overall, even though he sometimes needs to be alone to reflect.

Speaker2: [01:22:29] You mentioned this earlier, especially at the beginning of the interview, but I'd like to know if you feel secure in your relationship.

Speaker1: [01:22:39] Yes. Yes. I feel secure because - it's funny, we talked about this over the weekend. Yes, I feel secure because he shows me in many ways that I can trust him and that if there's an issue, he's there for me.

Speaker2: [01:22:57] There are two main notions in security: being able to open up to your partner about your experiences, your identity, who you are, without fearing repercussions or judgment, and the idea of receiving comfort or attention in times of distress. Do these two criteria apply to you?

Speaker1: [01:23:22] Yes, really. When I lost my uncle, my mother called me. I was at [partner]'s place, and he was exceptional. He was really there for me, in gestures, in what he said, the minimum but just there. Yes, that made me feel he was really there.

Speaker2: [01:23:58] Now I'd like to briefly address another aspect of couple relationships, sexuality. We know it can be more or less important in a relationship. Is it important to you?

Speaker1: [01:24:09] Yes. Yes, yes. I think it's part of the strength of our relationship. We love making love together; it's something we enjoy. That's why we quickly talked about the chemistry of bodies because it's something we haven't felt with others before. So it's an important dimension.

Speaker2: [01:24:50] It's an important dimension for you.

Speaker1: [01:24:52] Yes, our relationship is strong on many levels. It's very strong, what we live through in this relationship.

Speaker2: [01:25:08] So it also involves physical intimacy. It's both an understanding and shared vision, but also physical.

Speaker1: [01:25:18] Yes, this fusion aspect. Without losing oneself, but this fusion of bodies also, which works well and supports us.

Speaker2: [01:25:31] It plays an important role in the development of the relationship and makes you both feel comfortable.

Speaker1: [01:25:35] Yes, exactly.

Speaker2: [01:25:38] Can you tell me approximately how often you have sexual intercourse currently?

Speaker1: [01:25:45] I'd say maybe not every day, but [1-5] times a week.

Speaker2: [01:25:55] Are you satisfied with your sex life?

Speaker1: [01:25:59] Yes. Yes, really.

Speaker2: [01:26:02] Now, I'm going to show you a scale and ask you questions based on it. I'll share my screen.

Speaker1: [01:26:15] Okay.

Speaker2: [01:26:17] Tell me if you can see it.

Speaker1: [01:26:24] Yes.

Speaker2: [01:26:25] The idea is to tell me on this scale from 1 to 9 - from not at all true to completely true - how much you agree with the statement, "In general, my partner really listens to me."

Speaker1: [01:26:45] Yeah, it's eight or nine. Eight.

Speaker2: [01:26:49] Eight?

Speaker1: [01:26:52] Yes.

Speaker2: [01:26:53] Why do you rate it eight?

Speaker1: [01:26:56] Because I would have said completely true, but sometimes he's in his world, in his bubble, and tends not to hear. But when he's actively listening, he really listens. So he does really listen. But there are times when I tell him things, and he says, "Oh, by the way," and I say, "I just told you!" But that's because he's daydreaming or too absorbed by something else, and because I talk all the time, he can't always listen.

Speaker2: [01:27:26] You told me why you didn't rate it higher than eight, but why not seven or six?

Speaker1: [01:27:31] Because it depends on what type of listening we're talking about. If it's active listening when I really need him to listen, it's completely true. But for trivial discussions or everyday things, it might be six or seven. But "really listens," it's the "really" that brings it closer to nine.

Speaker2: [01:27:54] So what's important to you is...

Speaker1: [01:27:56] When I have something important to say, he really listens. If it's about active listening for a particular problem, I could rate it nine.

Speaker2: [01:28:11] Okay. The second statement: My partner is generally attentive to my needs.

Speaker1: [01:28:18] Ah, yes. Yes, yes, the same, it's completely true. Yes, it's eight or nine too. Eight or nine.

Speaker2: [01:28:32] You hesitate between the two.

Speaker1: [01:28:34] Because nine is too perfect. And we might think it's not possible. But yes, generally, we are. Yes, I would rate it eight. What makes me hesitate is that, for example, if I need him when he goes to his place because he needs to, there are times when I would have preferred he stayed. But it happened one night when I had a big problem, a bit tense, I can't remember what it was. It was bad news, I think. I was on the phone with him and said, "It's bad timing that you're not here tonight." He said, "I'm coming," and he drove 25 kilometers to be with me. So yes, generally, he is attentive to my needs.

Speaker2: [01:29:29] Okay, it's just not to describe perfection.

Speaker1: [01:29:32] Yes.

Speaker2: [01:29:33] I understand. How satisfied are you with your relationship?

Speaker1: [01:29:43] Very satisfied. Not completely, because there are always some complications, but I'm still close to perfection. It would be perfect if there wasn't this little depression problem.

Speaker2: [01:30:00] Now that you've explained it with words, if you had to rate it, knowing that zero is not at all satisfied and ten is completely satisfied, where would you place yourself for the same question?

Speaker1: [01:30:19] Between zero and ten? Between eight and ten... Eight, eight.

Speaker2: [01:30:26] So why not nine?

Speaker1: [01:30:33] A week ago, I might have said six or seven because I was scared when he wasn't doing well. Today, I could say ten because we had a great weekend, said a lot of things, and it was great. So that's why I say eight or nine. It depends on his state. But since 90% of the time, he's great, I'm at nine. I'm very satisfied. So ten is perfect.

Speaker2: [01:31:17] Very well. So eight or nine, depending on the moment. But you feel comfortable. We're about to conclude. I'll just summarize what we've discussed over the past hour. You tell me if it matches what you told me, if you want to add anything, or correct anything. So you met [partner] less than [1-5] year ago. You knew him for a long time since he was a neighbor and someone you had already interacted with because your children grew up around the same time. The meeting happened quite simply, organically, I think you said. You met because you needed help with something, and it developed naturally from there.

Speaker1: [01:32:13] Yes. I should specify that when I learned they were separating, I heard it from friends on [Event] [Year]. They told me, "By the way, your neighbors are separating." I thought, "My neighbors? Who?" "Well, [partner] and [ex-wife]." I said, "They're separating? Oh yeah?" And I repressed a huge smile. I thought he was an amazing guy.

Speaker2: [01:32:49] Even back then?

Speaker1: [01:32:50] Yes. I saw him as a neighbor who was always there, always helping, inviting the neighbors, cooking. I thought, "He's perfect! She's lucky to have him, but she doesn't realize it." I had thought that for a long time. When I found out he was free, I couldn't help but smile. I was happy he was free of her and also happy to know he was available.

Speaker2: [01:33:27] For him and for you, in a way.

Speaker1: [01:33:27] He was back on the market. (laughs) It's terrible to say that. (laughs) Soon after, in early [Month], [partner] came to the house, telling neighbors they were selling the house and separating. I told him, "Maybe it's for the best. Don't rush into another relationship, take the time to live and enjoy being alone." I didn't think it would happen with me. Then we met in [Month]. He moved out at the end of [Month], and we got together at the end of [Month]. So he took some time, but it was still a bit fast for him. I also need to clarify...

Speaker2: [01:34:21] Tell me.

Speaker1: [01:34:22] I didn't break my radiator on purpose to make him come, but I was happy when it broke. (laughs)

Speaker2: [01:34:31] Then you talked about your previous relationships and your friends' relationships, explaining that in your past relationships, there was a lack of trust, sometimes an imbalance, and that your friends' relationships sometimes lacked connection and even kindness. When we discussed what a high-quality relationship means to you, you used many words and adjectives: trust, communication, freedom.

Speaker1: [01:35:16] Freedom. One plus one equals three.

Speaker2: [01:35:18] Conversely, a low-quality relationship is one that is unbalanced or self-interested. Those were the two words you used to describe it. You said what is really important to you in a romantic relationship is a shared project, moving in the same direction. That was something that stood out. You said love is very important to you, even essential. It's the base, the foundation.

Speaker1: [01:35:50] Yes, it's the base.

Speaker2: [01:35:53] You told me how you know your partner loves you, through gestures and something you feel, something almost inexplicable.

Speaker1: [01:36:05] Yes, yes.

Speaker2: [01:36:06] You also talked about positive and negative interactions, mentioning the incident with your sister and how you debriefed it with him afterward. We talked about conflicts and how you manage to resolve them through communication before they escalate.

Speaker3: [01:36:27] Yes.

Speaker2: [01:36:31] You said this relationship is good for you, you feel it helps you regulate and achieve your goals.

Speaker1: [01:36:40] Yes. To be better, to be just, to... Yeah, to be better, to be better in my life, in...

Speaker2: [01:37:02] Okay.

Speaker2: [01:37:02] I think when you feel good, you transmit it better. For example, sometimes when I go to work with my students, if I'm not well, I always try not to show it. But when everything is good, everything goes well in class because you send out positive energy, smiles, etc. A smile brings a smile. When you feel good, you receive good, right? (laughs)

Speaker2: [01:37:32] I understand what you mean. You also told me that you don't think you have changed during this relationship, even though you described in detail how you changed compared to your previous relationships. But you feel he has changed during this relationship.

Speaker1: [01:37:59] I think he feels better. Everyone around him says so. Even a sister-in-law said, "You've transformed our [partner]. Thank you, [participant]." I said, "Yeah, it's because we're together." I think he was very unhappy in his previous relationship, and now he feels alive again.

Speaker2: [01:38:27] Is there anything else you'd like to add?

Speaker1: [01:38:30] No, I think that's it.

Speaker2: [01:38:37] Thank you. I just have two final questions.

Speaker1: [01:38:45] Yes.

Speaker2: [01:38:46] Quickly. We'll process the data afterward. There are two potential options for processing the data. The first option is we keep only parts of the transcription. Both options are anonymous. The first option is to keep only parts of the transcription, and the second option is to keep the entire interview. The advantage of keeping the entire interview is that it allows other researchers to verify our data, use it for other studies, etc. We always offer the choice because people might fear being identified - which is absolutely impossible because everything is anonymized. But it's an ethical duty we adhere to, always giving the choice to participants. Is there an option you feel more comfortable with?

Speaker1: [01:39:33] Honestly, if it can be useful, that's the point. So if our time together can help others, as long as it's anonymous, no problem.

Speaker2: [01:39:43] Great. Just one last thing. I'd like you to fill out a short questionnaire - two short questionnaires - one purely demographic and one a bit more detailed - but it's really five minutes. I'll send it to you. I'll stay here, but turn off the camera and mic to give you privacy while you fill it out. Once you're done, we're good.

Speaker1: [01:40:12] Okay, that works.

Speaker2: [01:40:18] I'll send it to you in the chat.

Speaker1: [01:40:33] Okay. I'm filling it out.